

Paper 1: Philosophy of Religion

Overview

The content for this paper helps students to explore some of the main contemporary philosophical issues and questions about religion, such as belief in God or the conviction that life has both meaning and purpose. It provides a relevant and challenging context for exploring the particular beliefs, values and practices that characterise religious communities. In turn, the paper provides a sound basis for understanding and reflecting on the contemporary influence of religion, the views of those who do not share a religious belief and the impact of these factors on people's lives.

Students will engage with arguments and debates on religious and non-religious views of life, which focus on some key areas of controversy that shape modern views of the world, such as the problem of evil and suffering. Students will extend their understanding through engagement in debates on issues such as the value of evidence based on accounts of religious experience. They will analyse and evaluate particular viewpoints of thinkers who have contributed to these debates.

Students will extend the breadth and depth of their study by considering how religious ideas are expressed and communicated, and how they may differ from other contemporary ways of expressing beliefs about the world – for instance whether religious and scientific language is incompatible or complementary, whether ideas about life after death are tenable in or relevant to the modern world. As part of this process, students will study how ideas about the philosophy of religion have changed over time, and the most important influences on this process. They will use the writings of key scholars to explore differing viewpoints about the development of ideas in the philosophy of religion. **These studies will give students the opportunity to explore links between this paper and other areas of study, such as the impact of beliefs and values on modern life, the importance of tradition in religious communities or the interpretation and application of religious texts in the modern world.**

It is compulsory for students to compare the work of two named scholars, including a specific extract of their work. The list of extracts at the end of the paper must be studied by all students and this includes the work of two named scholars for comparison. These are published in the *A Level Religious Studies Anthology: Paper 1 – Philosophy of Religion* which can be downloaded from our website. The context in which these texts could be studied is indicated by bracketed numbers in the detailed content, (1) for example. These extracts are **not** exclusive to the topic areas under which they appear; students will need to be able to apply these extracts across any suitable topic. This allows for a range of questions, including text or language specific, as well as thematic.

In this paper, students will be required to study the ideas of key contributors in relation to specific content areas. These are indicated against each relevant sub-topic. Students will be required to use these ideas to support and underpin their knowledge and understanding.

Overall, this study will enhance students' capacity to deal with controversial issues about beliefs and values, to have confidence in their ability to express their ideas and to put forward their own beliefs and ideals supported by reasoned argument and evidence.

Topics	What students need to learn	
1 Philosophical issues and questions	1.1	Design Argument a) Inductive reasoning, <i>a posteriori</i> types of arguments, interpretation of experience. b) Types of order and regularity, role of analogy, cumulative effect of evidence, anthropic principle, regularities of co-presence and regularities of succession. c) Strengths and weaknesses of Design Arguments: probability rather than proof, alternative interpretations, including evolution and deism. Challenges to the argument. d) Philosophical language and thought through significant concepts and the works of key thinkers, illustrated in issues in the philosophy of religion. With reference to the ideas of W Paley and D Hume.
	1.2	Cosmological Argument a) Inductive reasoning, <i>a posteriori</i> types of arguments. b) Principle of sufficient reason, explanation, interpretation of experience, movement, cause and effect, contingency, infinite regress, first cause, necessary existence, Kalam version. c) Strengths and weaknesses of Cosmological Arguments: probability rather than proof, brute fact, debates about infinite regress, necessary existence and God as a necessary being. Challenges to the argument. d) Philosophical language and thought through significant concepts and the works of key thinkers, illustrated in issues in the philosophy of religion. With reference to the ideas of Aquinas and D Hume, I Kant.
	1.3	Ontological Argument a) <i>A priori</i> compared to <i>a posteriori</i> types of arguments, deductive reasoning, not evidence based but understanding of concept 'God' as an analytic proposition. b) Definitions of 'God', necessary existence, aseity. c) Strengths and weaknesses of the Ontological Arguments: concept of proof compared to probability, debates about 'existence' and predicates. Challenges to the argument. d) Philosophical language and thought through significant concepts and the works of key thinkers, illustrated in issues in the philosophy of religion. With reference to the ideas of Anselm and B Russell.